

Taxidea taxus

American badger



Length 16½–28 in (42–72 cm)

Tail 4–6¼ in (10–16 cm)

Weight 17–19 lb (7.6–8.7 kg)

Social unit Individual

Status Least concern



Smaller than the Eurasian badger, the American badger has a somewhat flattened head and body, and a narrower central



white stripe that runs from nose to back. Its burrows are up to (3²³/₄ ft) (10 m) deep in well-drained soil of dry, open country, terminating in grassy nests. Unlike the European badger—but like most mustelids—the American badger is solitary except when breeding. It preys mainly on burrowing rodents, such as ground squirrels, but will also take birds, reptiles, and arthropods. Reportedly, it cooperates with coyotes, relying on the coyote’s superior sense of smell to locate prey, before the badger digs out the target with its stronger clawed feet; both predators share the prize. Usually 2 young are born in the nest after a pregnancy of 7 months. They are weaned after about 6 weeks.

Arctonyx collaris

Greater hog badger



Length 25½–41 in (65–104 cm)

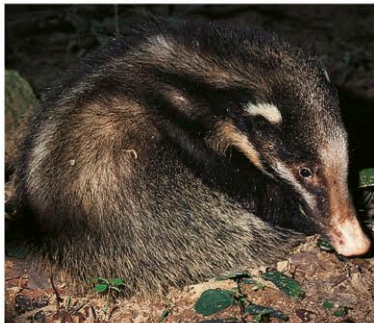
Tail 7¼–11¼ in (19–29 cm)

Weight 15–33 lb (7–15 kg)

Social unit Individual

Status Vulnerable





Named the world’s largest badger, the greater hog badger gets its name from its long, mobile, hairless, porcine snout—

something that it uses to root through forest litter and soil. The body of this warm-region species is more sparsely furred than those of badgers in temperate climates, but its white facial markings are reminiscent of those of the Eurasian badger. Details of the head-stripe pattern vary from individual to individual. A closely related shaggy-coated species of hog badger lives further north—in cooler parts of Tibet and the Himalayas, where it hibernates during winter. The greater hog badger lives in tropical woodlands, grassland, and plantations, especially in hill forests above 1,640 ft (500 m). It is active all year round and is omnivorous, supplementing a diet of invertebrates, small mammals, and reptiles with tubers and roots; it seems to be especially fond of earthworms. Hog badgers are nocturnal and solitary, with peak activities before dawn and after dark. They rest during the day in underground burrows or among rocks. A hog badger can defend itself with powerful jaws and a savage temperament; its skin is also thick and loose, and it has a pungent anal gland secretion. Births usually happen in February or March, producing litters of 3 to 5 young. The young are weaned after 4 months.

Enhydra lutris

Sea otter



Length 1¾–4¼ ft (55–130 cm)

Tail 5–13 in (13–33 cm)

Weight 46–62 lb (21–28 kg)

Social unit Group

Status Endangered



The smallest marine mammal, the sea otter lives and feeds in the ocean. It comes ashore only rarely, but is commonly seen close to the coast, particularly near marine kelp forests, floating on its back with its paws out of the water. Superbly adapted to its aquatic way of life, the sea otter has luxuriantly thick fur that keeps it warm in the cold waters it inhabits. It has a

strong, flat tail that acts as a rudder, and large, flipperlike hind feet that propel it through the water; the smaller forepaws have retractable claws, like a cat’s, which the sea otter uses for holding food and grooming its fur. Excellent eyesight—both underwater and at the surface—a good sense of smell, and sensitive whiskers help it to find food. It forages mainly on the seabed, looking for crabs, clams, sea urchins, and abalone, and has immensely strong teeth for chewing crab shells once they have been broken using a rock. Before the sea otter sleeps, it may anchor itself by wrapping its body in kelp. Sea otters are social animals, usually found in groups (rafts), with males forming separate rafts from females. In Alaska, hundreds of animals may be found together. Although hunted in the past for its fur—almost to extinction in some areas—the sea otter is now a protected species.

GROOMING TO STAY WARM
The sea otter has the densest fur of all animals—up to 1 million hairs per square inch. Grooming the fur, to keep it clean and waterproof, is essential.

SPECIALIZED BEHAVIOR

The sea otter is a resourceful and adept animal, adapting its behavior in a variety of ways in order to make the most of its environment. Perhaps most remarkably, it has learned to use stones as tools for cracking open shellfish.



TOOL USER

The sea otter is able to break the shells and tough protective outer coverings of crabs and sea urchins. Lying on its back, it breaks them open by hitting them against a rock collected from the sea bed.

CONSERVATION

Protected from hunting, sea otter numbers have now recovered and stabilized, but only in parts of their original range. Conservation focuses on maintaining healthy kelp forests, so that sea otters have suitable habitats and a reliable source of food. In recent years, sea otters have been successfully reintroduced along the west coast of North America, although the species’ range is still much smaller than it was before hunting began. Yet another major threat facing these creatures is oil spills.



